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Hochschule Darmstadt
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Intercultural Communication

Nationalism: A Threat or a Shield?

How Perspectives Differ Across Nations

Full Essay of Topic

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Nationalism, in its core definition, is the belief in the sovereignty of a nation and the preservation of its unique identity, culture, and interests. However, nationalism's meaning varies across the world depending on historical contexts, political structures, and perceptions of security. While civic nationalism emphasizes shared values and citizenship regardless of ethnicity, ethnic nationalism focuses on the ethnic and cultural preservation of the nation, often linking it to race or religion.

Nationalism's fluidity becomes especially apparent when comparing powerful nations like the USA, where nationalism is often linked to expansion and intervention, to smaller, historically threatened countries like Greece and Cyprus, where nationalism can act as a form of self-defence and cultural survival.

This essay argues that nationalism is neither inherently good nor bad; rather, it shifts in meaning depending on the nation's history, geopolitical situation, and its perceived security threats. The following sections explore these dynamics in detail, with real-world examples illustrating the varying roles of nationalism in both domestic and international contexts.

Nationalism is a multifaceted ideology, often understood as a collective identity or allegiance to one’s nation. It emphasizes the sovereignty of a nation-state and the importance of preserving its cultural, political, and economic autonomy. However, nationalism can take different forms, primarily divided into civic nationalism and ethnic nationalism.

Civic nationalism is inclusive, based on shared values, political institutions, and citizenship. It is typically associated with modern liberal democracies, where nationality is determined by one's allegiance to the state's values rather than by ethnicity or heritage. Examples include France and the United States, where individuals are integrated into the nation based on political equality, individual rights, and a shared commitment to national values.

In contrast, ethnic nationalism focuses on ethnicity, race, and shared heritage, often excluding those who do not belong to the dominant ethnic group. This form is usually seen in countries with a strong cultural or historical identity, such as Germany and Hungary, where ethnic lineage plays a significant role in defining membership in the national community. Ethnic nationalism can sometimes lead to exclusion, xenophobia, and ethnocentrism, as it emphasizes the primacy of ethnic identity over civic or political unity.

Nationalism’s meaning and function are deeply influenced by a country’s history, its geopolitical position, and its perceived security needs. In large, powerful nations, nationalism often reflects ideas of dominance and superiority, while in smaller, historically threatened nations, it can serve as a protective shield, reinforcing cultural survival and sovereignty.

The concept of nationalism evolves in response to historical, geographical, and political factors, shaping how it is understood in different regions.. This section explores how nationalism has been perceived and practiced in Germany, the USA, Greece, and Cyprus, demonstrating nationalism's contrasting functions: aggressive expansion and defensive protection.

Germany: Nationalism as a Historical Threat:

Germany exemplifies nationalism shaped by historical trauma. In the early 20th century, nationalism was tied to expansionism, militarism, and racial superiority, especially during World War II. Hitler's regime turned nationalism into an ideology that justified invasions and the suppression of ethnic minorities.

After WWII, nationalism became controversial. In post-war Germany, nationalism is viewed with suspicion due to its association with extremism. Today, German nationalism is literally non – existent. Today Germany remains cautious to avoid aggressive nationalism.

USA: Nationalism as a Tool of Expansion and Dominance:

In the United States, nationalism has been a means of expansion and military intervention. The idea of Manifest Destiny justified territorial expansion, such as the annexation of Texas and the Mexican-American War.

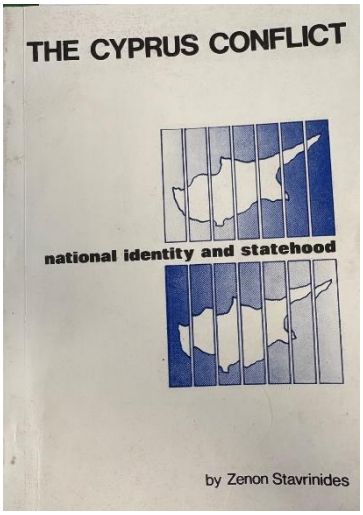
In the 20th and 21st centuries, U.S. nationalism became intertwined with global leadership. Nationalism during the Cold War justified military actions in Vietnam, Iraq, and Afghanistan, positioning the U.S. as a global superpower. This form of aggressive nationalism is linked to ideas of dominance and military superiority.

Greece: Nationalism as Cultural Survival:

In Greece, nationalism emerged as a defensive mechanism against foreign domination. After centuries of Ottoman occupation, nationalism preserved language, culture, and faith. During the Greek War of Independence (1821–1830), nationalism unified Greeks against the Ottomans.

Today, Greek nationalism remains protective, driven by the memory of occupation and ongoing tensions with Turkey over the Aegean Sea. It serves to defend sovereignty and maintain cultural identity.

Cyprus: Nationalism as a Survival Mechanism:



Similarly, Cyprus has experienced occupation and division. Following the Turkish invasion in 1974, the island was split into the Turkish-occupied north and the Greek-controlled south. Greek Cypriot nationalism defends sovereignty and identity from perceived external threats.

Nationalism in Cyprus is a defensive survival mechanism, preserving national identity and unity amid division and external pressures.

Nationalism Depends on Context:

These examples: Germany, USA, Greece, and Cyprus, show that nationalism is not static. it shifts based on historical experience, geopolitical situation, and security needs. In Germany, nationalism is cautious due to its aggressive past. In the USA, nationalism often takes an expansionist and military form, while in Greece and **Cyprus**, nationalism serves as a protective shield, preserving identity and sovereignty.

In the United States, nationalism is often framed as a tool of domination and exclusion, particularly in relation to immigration policy and foreign intervention. The actions of ICE (Immigration and Customs Enforcement) in Minnesota provide a stark example of how nationalism is used to enforce control and project state power. In recent months, ICE agents have been accused of using violent tactics in operations aimed at detaining undocumented immigrants. For instance, Operation Metro Surge saw an increase in raids that led to fatalities and sparked widespread protests. Critics describe the violence as part of a broader agenda of racial exclusion and state overreach, highlighting how nationalism in the U.S. is often tied to a narrative of security and domestic protection—but at the cost of human rights.



On the international stage, U.S. nationalism has manifested through aggressive foreign policies, such as its rhetoric and actions in Venezuela. Under the Trump administration, the U.S. adopted a hardline stance against Nicolás Maduro, promoting regime change by supporting opposition groups and threatening military intervention. This form of nationalism is rooted in the belief that the U.S. has the right to influence or even reshape foreign governments, based on its self-proclaimed role as a global leader and the so called “protector of democracy”.

Another example of U.S. nationalism on the world stage is its interest in Greenland. The U.S. administration, notably President Trump, expressed interest in purchasing Greenland, an attempt to expand American territorial influence in the Arctic. This reflects a broader pattern of aggressive nationalism, where the U.S. seeks to assert its

power through territorial expansion and military strategy, ignoring sovereignty concerns from Denmark, Greenland, and the European Union.

Nationalism is context-dependent and its meaning changes based on a nation's history, geopolitical standing, and security needs. Throughout this essay, we have seen how nationalism in Germany is viewed with caution due to its historical ties to aggression, while in the USA, nationalism often takes on an expansionist and military form. In contrast, Greece and Cyprus illustrate how nationalism can function as a defensive tool, preserving cultural identity and sovereignty in the face of external threats and historical trauma.

The recent actions of the USA, including ICE's violent enforcement in Minnesota, its desire to acquire Greenland, and the aggressive foreign stance towards Venezuela, all provide modern examples of how nationalism is wielded as a tool for power, whether domestically or on the world stage. These examples illustrate the two faces of nationalism: one as a threat of exclusion and domination, and the other as a shield of cultural survival and unity.

Ultimately, nationalism remains a dynamic force that shapes countries in distinct ways, influenced by each nation's past experiences and present-day challenges.